

[Return to Search](#)

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The dynamics of clanship among the Tallensi

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When the natives speak of this as brother-in-lawship, they make it clear that they are speaking figuratively. A clan's joking partners are usually clans that live just beyond the range of its effective ties of clanship. They are clans who actually are or might be the *sunz(ɔ)p* of its *sunz(ɔ)p* by clanship or by courtesy. Thus they lie on the border between two zones. On the one side lies the zone in which the clan has precisely defined social ties implying specific rights and obligations and resting on the assumption of amity and solidarity. Serious conflict with these clans is regarded as incompatible with the basic axioms of social relations, and when it occurs it always precipitates action designed to re-establish normal social relations. On the other side live people with whom no direct structural ties exist; they may be friendly if they wish, but they can be hostile with impunity. They are clans whose wives can be abducted or seduced, if one is bold enough, without infringing the loyalty of clanship or necessarily incurring instant reprisals.

[602  
Kin Relationships](#)[608  
Artificial Kin  
Relationships](#)[618  
Localized Kin Groups](#)

Joking partners lie between these two sets of clans, and are likely to be connected with both by structural ties of one kind or another. Thus the joking partners of my clan are not our *sunz(ɔ)p* nor our possible but inaccessible enemies. They are the *sunz(ɔ)p* of our *sunz(ɔ)p*, in relation to whom both my clan and theirs have similar rights, obligations, and sentiments. This is a bond of friendliness between us. But they are also the *sunz(ɔ)p* of our possible enemies, who may side with them against us, and this is a source of latent opposition between us. The conventions of the joking relationship symbolize piquantly the interstitial status of joking partners between friends, who have rights, duties, and loyalties to one another, and potential enemies. Their privileged aggression reconciles the conflicting definitions of *sunz(ɔ)p*, whose right to a share of the meat symbolizes reciprocal bonds, and non-*sunz(ɔ)p*

[602  
Kin Relationships](#)[608  
Artificial Kin  
Relationships](#)[618  
Localized Kin Groups](#)

who have no right to it because of the absence of reciprocal obligations; of people who are near (*p(ɔ)r(ə)ga*)—a significant concept in Tale political thought indicating both spatial and social proximity—and those who are far (*zaa ha*); of people whose friendliness can be relied upon, and those who are incalculable.

This is obvious both in the custom of mock abuse and in the snatching of meat or other food at a funeral ceremony. The joking partners obtain a share of the meat almost as if they were *sunz(ɔ)p*—but by a burlesque of 93 seizing it by violence, almost as if they were hostile intruders. *Sunz(ɔ)p* have *a priori* no need of force to assert their privileges; if they did resort to it the affront would be so grave as to rupture the ties of clanship with them. Unrelated strangers could only get one of the shares due to *sunz(ɔ)p* if they had the temerity to seize it—but they would be fortunate if they escaped with their lives, even in these days of curbed passions. The mock aggression of a joking partner is a caricature blending these contradictory ways of behaviour.

602

Kin Relationships

608

Artificial Kin  
Relationships

618

Localized Kin Groups

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